Ranking principles: the cheat sheet

How Google and AI answers judge a page, in 12 lines. Pin it next to your editor, or paste it into Claude before it writes anything. From Google's own guidance (people-first content page, updated Oct 5, 2026; Search Quality Rater Guidelines, Sept 11, 2025) and the research on what AI answers quote. Checked November 2026.

#	Principle	Do this
1	One reader, one problem	Write one line first: who searches, the words they type, what "done" looks like for them.
2	Answer first	The title promises it, the first 2–3 sentences deliver it. No warm-up intro.
3	Add what the top 5 don't have	List what they all say, then add one thing none of them do: your numbers, a test, a real example, a cost breakdown.
4	Show you've done it	What it cost, how long it took, what broke. Your own photos, screenshots and dates.
5	Be specific	Numbers, names, places, dates, units. "Fast" → "loads in 1.2 s on 4G". Every number has a source.
6	Cite real sources	Link the primary source right where the claim is made. Quote real people by name.
7	Lines that work quoted alone	Start each section with a plain sentence that answers its heading. Facts in text, not only in images.
8	Show who wrote it and why	Real byline and bio. Say how you made it. Disclose that you sell the thing.
9	Fact-check everything	Every number, price, date and quote against its source, AI drafts most of all.
10	Let the effort show	Delete paragraphs any page could contain. Add a table, a calculator or an annotated screenshot.
11	Keep it current, honestly	Update when facts change, say what changed, then change the date. Never bump a date alone.
12	Be worth quoting	One clear stat, a date, a method, a named author. Earned mentions beat link tricks.

Habits Google says don't help

- **Writing to a word count.** Google: there's "no magical word count target, minimum or maximum" (SEO Starter Guide).
- **Repeating the keyword.** Keyword stuffing is against Google's spam policies. In the GEO study it scored below baseline in AI answers.
- **An FAQ section for the rich result.** Since Aug 2023 FAQ rich results only show for well-known government and health sites.

- **Special files or schema for AI Overviews (llms.txt).** Google's AI features doc: you don't need new machine-readable files, AI text files or markup.
- **New date, same page.** Google lists it as a warning sign.

3 numbers worth knowing

- **+30–40%** visibility in AI-generated answers from adding cited sources, quotes and statistics; keyword stuffing scored below baseline. (Aggarwal et al., GEO, KDD 2024, arxiv.org/abs/2311.09735)
- **38%** of AI Overview citations rank in Google's top 10 for the same search, so pages outside the top 10 get quoted too. (Ahrefs, Mar 2, 2026, ahrefs.com/blog/ai-overview-citations-top-10)
- **44.2%** of ChatGPT citations come from the first 30% of a page: answer first. (Kevin Indig / Gauge, Search Engine Journal, Feb 17, 2026; correlational)

The prompt

"Use ranking principles to write a page about [topic] for [reader]. First show me the reader card, what the top 5 results all say, and the one thing we'll add that they don't. Ask me for my own numbers or examples; don't invent any."

Audit instead: "Audit [URL] with ranking principles: score each principle 0–2 with evidence, then the 5 edits that matter most, in order."

Free skill (ranking-principles) + 13 more: github.com/WordRocket/claude-seo-skills · Sources: Google: people-first content · SEO Starter Guide · AI features and your website. Made by WordRocket (wordrocket.ai), our own tool. Nobody honest can promise rankings: results vary.